

“Look back at time ... before our birth. In this way Nature holds before our eyes the mirror of our future after death. Is this so grim, so gloomy?”

Because this draws a kind of parallel between pre-birth and post-death times,
this is sometimes called the **symmetry argument**.

One can think of Luncratius' second argument as a reply to this objection.

Most of us have a negative feeling about future nonexistence which we do not have about past nonexistence. Lucretius' challenge is to justify this difference in our attitudes.

A natural reply is to say: 'OK, I agree that there is nothing especially fearsome about my past nonexistence. But future nonexistence is different; I should fear my future nonexistence even if I do not fear my past nonexistence.'

The fact is that people do systematically exhibit **time bias**: they prefer good things to be in their future and bad things in their past. The interesting question raised by the symmetry argument is whether this feature of human thinking is a rational one, or one we should attempt to overcome. If the latter is correct, then the symmetry argument has considerable force.

But why **shouldn't** we feel about post-death nonexistence the same way we feel about pre-birth nonexistence? Why would it be rational to have very different attitudes toward two equivalent states of affairs just because they happen to occupy different locations in time? We don't, after all, make parallel distinctions between events occurring in different locations in space.



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